

# Mary Mayo



## When Imagination Stopped

As a child, the world was one big question mark. Without awareness of how things functioned and why things were the way they were, the only tool a child has is imagination. I imagined a lot. Creativity used to feel like something that arrived unannounced, a visitor I would always allow in. I used to look at a page and let my ideas spew out, unfiltered and unafraid. There was no pressure, no expectation of perfection. The lines were crooked, the words were misspelled, and logic ceased to exist. It was pure, untouched by self-doubt or structure. In those early years, creativity was a companion that asked for nothing more than attention. My writing and art consisted of imaginary creatures and adventures into faraway lands –castles made of candy, trips into outer space, and talking animals that spoke in a language only children could understand. Over time, I went from welcoming creativity whenever it showed up to putting it on a leash. Ideas had to be "worth it" to write down, and sketches had to be "good enough" to share. I started editing before I even began writing. The imagination became more about the final product rather than the idea that had once propelled me forward. For creatives, this is often what happens as

we become older. Our work must always be measured against some invisible standard, questioning if what we make is relevant and good enough. However, it leads me to question if any art is actually "good enough" and who makes up the jury? As we grow up, we often hand over the right to define our art, whether it's by critics, algorithms, or portfolio reviews. Yet the truth is, the only thing art belongs to is the maker. I often find myself thinking back to those early days of creating, questioning why that innocence and confidence fades in our work as we age. I came to the conclusion that the art we make is dependent on how we see the world. As a child, the world was big and inviting. As an adult, the world begins to suffocate under the weight of what we think we already know, leaving less room for wonder. Maybe that's why, as adults, we need art more than ever. Art is one of the last places where we can still pretend. We spend most of our days processing an excessive amount of information, feelings, and the dread that comes from knowing too much. Whether

's an adult, the world begins to suffocate under the weight of what we think we already know, leaving less room for wonder. Maybe that's why, as adults, we need



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